

[Return to Search](#)

Baba of Karo, a woman of the Muslim Hausa

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Kinship and Marriage

Hausa kinship is markedly bilateral—that is, traced through persons of either sex—both in terminology and behaviour. Marriage is virilocal, the woman coming to live with the man, usually in his father's compound if it is the man's first marriage. Cross-cousin marriages of both types are now made, though matrilineal cross-cousin marriage (i.e. that between a man and his mother's brother's daughter) was probably the traditional form. Parallel-cousin marriages of both types are also found, the marriages between children of brothers, which is preferred in Islam, being far more frequent than the marriages between children of sisters. Adoption is an important feature of Hausa kinship, and is most frequent for the first-born, being either maternal or paternal according to circumstances. Usually adoption takes place after weaning at two years. A rigid lifelong public avoidance is observed between parents and their first-born child of either sex, and use of their parents' names is forbidden to all children. The last-born child is the playmate of its parents, and has a special name— *auta*, the child of old age. Joking relationships, expressed by privileged behaviour such as teasing, and the right to appropriate certain possessions of the other party, obtain between children and their grandparents, and between children of a sister and a brother, in both cases the first-named parties being privileged to tease and take things from the last-named, who retaliate with good-natured abuse and more teasing. There are also certain other joking relations, such as a man and his elder brother's wife, who behave in a similar way.

551
[Personal Names](#)

582
[Regulation Of Marriage](#)

591
[Residence](#)

593
[Family Relationships](#)

597
[Adoption](#)

611
[Rules Of Descent](#)

851
[Social Placement](#)

As marriage is virilocal and usually patrilocal, the core of the co-residential unit is a group of males linked by ties of kinship traced through males. Where

596
[Extended Families](#)

such a group exploits large resources together, or where important political office is vested in the patriline, groups emerge with greater or less degree of lineage structure, corporateness, and size. At the highest level, for instance in the case of the three principal Fulani dynasties of Zaria state, genealogies  22 with a depth of seven generations are remembered, but generally the rule is that where trace of office is lacking, genealogical memory is shallow, and bilateral kinship connections with extensive lateral ramifications are emphasized, rather than unilineal descent beyond three generations.

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